

Mahiya

The summer sun had just disappeared behind the towering apartment buildings, leaving a faint orange glow on the horizon. The chaotic buzz of traffic could not be heard in the hidden streets of Manhattan, where a pair of teenagers walked in search of an ice cream store. They had been introduced to each other a mere hour before but still managed to strike up a conversation.

The stage imitates a quiet New York City street, dimly lit by dark gray light emanating from lamp posts that are scattered across the stage. A backdrop with the design of New York City apartments is draped over the back wall and slowly moves throughout the scene to give the impression that the two characters are walking down the street. Open, dark brown window frames are hung from the ceiling and move alongside the backdrop.

The boy, Ibrahim, moved to Lahore, Pakistan, from New York City in the summer of 2020; he is the main focus of the scene. The stagecraft elements in the scene all pertain to him: the lighting is orchestrated by his emotions, and the screen device (that occasionally illuminates in the sky above the pair) showcases his most memorable moments. His companion, Maliha, has lived in New York all her life and acts as a confidante. There is a third character that is never seen, and his presence is solely the sound of his music.

IBRAHIM: Absolutely not. [He says while shaking his head, trying to hide the smile on his face.]

MALIHA: You're in denial! Admit it!

IBRAHIM: Nope. Van Leeuwen has the best chocolate ice cream.

MALIHA: Whatever you say. [She throws her hands up in defeat.]

IBRAHIM: It's been years since I've tried Häagen-Dazs, so maybe that's why.

MALIHA: Oh...yeah. They definitely don't have it in Pakistan. Your dad was telling me that he bought an ice cream machine before you guys moved, though.

IBRAHIM: Yeah, he found Van Leeuwen's recipes online, but he only makes Pistachio for himself.

MALIHA: Ew, that's horrible.

IBRAHIM: Yeah, real ice cream is one of the things I miss most about New York.

MALIHA: Was the transition hard? My mom always wanted to move back, but my dad is super against it.

IBRAHIM: Well, I go to an international school in Lahore, but the Pakistani mindset is definitely notable.

MALIHA: How so?

IBRAHIM: I mean, like... y'know how every brown dude's aspiration is to be a coder?

MALIHA: Haha yeah.

IBRAHIM: Yeah, so, there aren't many electives offered in subjects that aren't like math, computer science, and stuff.

MALIHA: Oh yeah, that sucks.

[They fall into a comfortable silence for a few seconds until Maliha asks:]

What's your favorite class in school?

IBRAHIM: Computer science. [he jokes]

MALIHA: Okay, totally.

IBRAHIM: I've grown to like chemistry and physics. But when I still lived in New York, my school offered an elective on modern art history.

[A window frame passes overhead, and the song "Mahiya" plays from the figurative apartment above.]

MALIHA: That's cool. I find art history interesting, but my school doesn't really offer any classes on it.

IBRAHIM: You should still look into it sometime, though. My sister and I went to the MoMA today for the first time in years. [he says with a laugh.]

MALIHA: You like going to museums in your free time?

IBRAHIM: Yeah... I used to go to the MoMA every Saturday before we moved. It was cool because I used to get there before all the crowds, the museum halls would be empty, and I could stand right in front of the pieces without having to worry about blocking someone else's view.

[*Sky image: A vacant museum hall.*]

It used to be the highlight of my week, and besides the *fantastic* ice cream in New York, the museums are probably what I miss the most.

MALIHA: That sucks. Especially because I know that if you somehow manage to find a museum in Pakistan, it'll be something about the Air Force.

IBRAHIM: Yeah, haha. Do you have a favorite art period?

MALIHA: Um, well, I like Pre-Raphaelite just because the art is absolutely gorgeous.

IBRAHIM: Do you have a favorite piece?

MALIHA: I mean, I'm literally obsessed with *Ophelia* by Millais. It's my profile picture for all my accounts. But what about you?

IBRAHIM: Eh, the renaissance, probably. It's basic, I know, but it's interesting how it set the stage for the Enlightenment. [he shrugs his shoulders before continuing:]

My teacher used to question, "if art was dictated by history or if history was dictated by art?" when she taught the unit. I think the renaissance is a perfect example of a situation where you can't really draw clear lines.

[*The lighting begins gradually shifting from dark gray tones to light yellow while he is talking. His voice becomes stronger and more confident as the conversation goes on.*]

MALIHA: That's an interesting hypothetical.

IBRAHIM: Yeah. Do you... do you like history?

MALIHA: Uhh, to an extent. I'm *very* picky, haha.

IBRAHIM: Hah. What do you like?

MALIHA: European history, mainly. I've been obsessed with Mary Stuart for a while now. What about you?

IBRAHIM: American's interesting.

MALIHA: No!

IBRAHIM: Why? Do you not? [he asks with a lighthearted laugh.]

MALIHA: It's not the worst, but I can't find it interesting. I'm applying for an internship at the New-York Historical Society, and the program revolves around American history.

IBRAHIM: That'll be interesting. Maybe it'll spark your interest.

MALIHA: I'm pretty sure I'll die of boredom when I'm there.

[They laugh and walk in silence for a while until Maliha asks:]

Do you want to become a historian?

IBRAHIM: I mean, I guess. But the chances of me getting the opportunity are close to zero.

[Sky image: a daunting computer screen]

[They stop at the corner of a street for five seconds. While they are stopped, he pauses and continues when they begin walking again:]

When I first moved, I tried holding onto my love for history, but it didn't help my... social situation. So I kinda gave up after a while and worked harder to understand math cause I suck at it. Everyone in my year is going into computer science, so I might as well.

[The music fades into silence as he says this, and as they continue walking, the lighting slowly loses its vibrancy and shifts into a light gray again. A soft white light appears in the right stage wing and shines on their faces. They walk towards the fluorescent light of the Van Leeuwen store as the scene fades out.]

Translations– Urdu to English:

1. *Mahiya*- Joyousness